

Close Reading 1

Consider the world-building strategies used in the following paragraph.

"In those days the Kargad Empire was strong. Those are four great lands that lie between the Northern and the Eastern Reaches: Karego-At, Atuan, Hur-at-Hur, Atnini. The tongue they speak there is not like any spoken in the Archipelago or the other Reaches, and they are a savage people, white-skinned, yellowhaired, and fierce, liking the sight of blood and the smell of burning towns."

1. How does the author introduce the people of the Kargad Empire? How does she sketch the geography? How does she show what they look like and what their temperament is like?
2. Exercise. Mirror the author's sentence structure to do some world-building of your own. Fill in the following:

"In ____ the ____ was _____. Those are _____ that lie _____ the _____:
_____. The tongue they speak there is _____, and they
are a _____ people, _____-skinned, _____haired, and _____, liking the sight of
_____ and the smell of _____."

Close Reading 2

"He looked down at his thin arms, wet with cold fogdew, and raged at his weakness, for he knew his strength. There was power in him, if he knew how to use it, and he sought among all the spells he knew for some device that might give him and his companions an advantage, or at least a chance. But need alone is not enough to set power free: there must be knowledge."

1. Consider the line "need alone is not enough to set power free: there must be knowledge." Have you ever felt like you needed power, but could not have it? Consider that the author says if there is knowledge, power is "set free". Do you agree with the author? Does knowledge set power free?

Close Reading 3

"Now need called knowledge out: Duny, seeing the fog blow and thin across the path before the Kargs, saw a spell that might avail him. An old weatherworker of the Vale, seeking to win the boy as prentice, had taught him several charms. One of these tricks was called fogweaving, a binding-spell that gathers the mists together for a while in one place; with it one skilled in illusion can shape the mist into fair ghostly seemings, which last a little and fade away. The boy had no such skill, but his intent was different, and he had the strength to turn the spell to his own ends. "

1. The "knowledge" Duny sees is a fog that happens to be blowing. Notice that Duny's knowledge isn't where it might be expected, such as in a book in a study. Instead, it is in what the weather happens to be. What does this imply about the author's view of knowledge?

Close Reading 4

Consider the way Duny's father is portrayed:

"[W]hen he was strong enough to push and pull the long bellows-sleeves, his father made him work as smith's boy, at a high cost in blows and whippings."

"Even as he did so his father coming up behind him struck him hard on the side of the head, knocking him right down. "Be still, fool! keep your blattering mouth shut, and hide if you can't fight!"

"The smith stared at his son who stood wraithlike in that weird, dank mist. It took him a minute to see Duny's meaning, but when he did he ran at once, noiselessly, knowing every fence and corner of the village, to find the others and tell them what to do."

"Sir," said the bronze-smith who would not let a great name daunt him, "my son will be thirteen this month coming, but we thought to hold his Passage at the feast of Sunreturn this winter."

"Let him be named as soon as may be," said the mage, "for he needs his name. I have other business now, but I will come back here for the day you choose. If you see fit I will take him with me when I go thereafter. And if he prove apt I will keep him as prentice, or see to it that he is schooled as fits his gifts. For to keep dark the mind of the mageborn, that is a dangerous thing."

Very gently Ogion spoke, but with certainty, and even the hardheaded smith assented to all he said."

1. What do you think of the father? Despite beating Duny, is he a good father?

Close Reading 5

"Ged fetched what he had to carry, which was the good bronze knife his father had forged him, and a leather coat the tanner's widow had cut down to his size, and an alderstick his aunt had becharmed for him: that was all he owned besides his shirt and breeches. He said farewell to them, all the people he knew in all the world, and looked about once at the village that straggled and huddled there under the cliffs, over the river-springs. Then he set off with his new master through the steep slanting forests of the mountain isle, through the leaves and shadows of bright autumn."

1. If you were leaving everyone you knew for a new world, what objects would you carry?
2. Notice the objects Ged chooses to carry. Each of them are gifts from people who are important to him. Does the fact that they are gifts from such people make a difference? Do you have any such objects?

Close Reading 6

"Though a very silent man he was so mild and calm that Ged soon lost his awe of him, and in a day or two more he was bold enough to ask his master,

"When will my apprenticeship begin, Sir?"

"It has begun," said Ogion.

There was a silence, as if Ged was keeping back something he had to say. Then he said it:

"But I haven't learned anything yet!"

"Because you haven't found out what I am teaching," replied the mage, going on at his steady, long-legged pace along their road, which was the high pass between Ovark and Wiss. He was a dark man, like most Gontishmen, dark copper-brown; grey-haired, lean and tough as a hound, tireless. He spoke seldom, ate little, slept less. His eyes and ears were very keen, and often there was a listening look on his face."

Ged did not answer him. It is not always easy to answer a mage.

"You want to work spells," Ogion said presently, striding along. "You've drawn too much water from that well. Wait. Manhood is patience. Mastery is nine times patience. What is that herb by the path?"

"Strawflower."

"And that?"

"I don't know."

"Fourfoil, they call it." Ogion had halted, the coppershod foot of his staff near the little weed, so Ged looked closely at the plant, and plucked a dry seedpod from it, and finally asked, since Ogion said nothing more, "What is its use, Master?"

"None I know of."

Ged kept the seedpod a while as they went on, then tossed it away.

"When you know the fourfoil in all its seasons root and leaf and flower, by sight and scent and seed, then you may learn its true name, knowing its being: which is more than its use."

1. What do you think Ogion is trying to teach?
2. What does Ogion mean with "then you may learn its true name, knowing its being: which is more than its use." What is a "true name" in this sense? What does it mean to "know its being"? How is something's "being" different from something's "use"?

Close Reading 7

Consider the world-building strategies used in the following paragraph:

“Along towards Sunreturn when the first heavy snows began to fall in the heights of Gont they came to Re Albi, Ogion’s home. It is a town on the edge of the high rocks of Overfell, and its name means Falcon’s Nest. From it one can see far below the deep harbor and the towers of the Port of Gont, and the ships that go in and out the gate of the bay between the Armed Cliffs, and far to the west across the sea one may make out the blue hills of Oranea, easternmost of the Inward Isles.”

1. How does the author introduce Re Albi’s geography?
2. Write about a town of your own imagination, mirroring the author’s sentence structure.

Close Reading 8

“[H]e stopped on a page that bore a spell of summoning up the spirits of the dead.

As he read it, puzzling out the runes and symbols one by one, a horror came over him. His eyes were fixed, and he could not lift them till he had finished reading all the spell.

Then raising his head he saw it was dark in the house. He had been reading without any light, in the darkness. He could not now make out the runes when he looked down at the book. Yet the horror grew in him, seeming to hold him bound in his chair. He was cold. Looking over his shoulder he saw that something was crouching beside the closed door, a shapeless clot of shadow darker than the darkness. It seemed to reach out towards him, and to whisper, and to call to him in a whisper: but he could not understand the words.”

1. Why do you think Duny is terrified, other than for the fact that he is reading a spell on raising the dead? Consider that the first spell Duny casts against the ghosts also terrifies him. Duny’s aunt fears Duny when he laughs at her spell, and the village children begin to fear Duny when he gets to a certain level of wizardry. Why does the author often use fear as the emotion that is evoked when encountering magical power one does not understand? What does this say about the author’s view of magic and magical power?
2. What do you think this shadow is?

Close Reading 9

“Ogion knelt down and built the fire on the hearth and lit it, for the house was cold. Then still kneeling he said in his quiet voice, “Ged, my young falcon, you are not bound to me or to my service. You did not come to me, but I to you. You are very young to make this choice, but I cannot make it for you. If you wish, I will send you to Roke Island, where all high arts are taught. Any craft you undertake to learn you will learn, for your power is great. Greater even than your pride, I hope. I would keep you here with me, for what I have is what you lack, but I will not keep you against your will. Now choose between Re Albi and Roke.”

1. What does Ogion mean by “for your power is great. Greater even than your pride, I hope.” What does this imply about the relation between power and pride?

Close Reading 10

“The master of the Shadow was a big man, and fat, in a red cloak trimmed with pellawi-fur such as Andradean merchants wear. He never looked at Ged but asked him in a mighty voice, “Can you work weather, boy?”

“I can. “

“Can you bring the wind?”

He had to say he could not, and with that the master told him to find a place out of the way and stay in it.”

“Rainwater dripped from the hem of the master’s cloak, but he stood stout as a winebarrel on his bit of decking and looking down at Ged he asked, “Can you abate this wind, lad?”

“No, sir.”

“Have you craft with iron?”

He meant, could Ged make the compass-needle point their way to Roke, making the magnet follow not its north but their need. That skill is a secret of the Seamasters, and again Ged must say no.

Well then," the master bellowed through the wind and rain, "you must find some ship to take you back to Roke from Hort Town. Roke must be west of us now, and only wizardry could bring us there through this sea. We must keep south."

Ged did not like this, for he had heard the sailors talk of Hort Town, how it was a lawless place, full of evil traffic, where men were often taken and sold into slavery in the South Reach."

"[C]atching hold of the carved prow to keep from being pitched overboard he shouted up to the master, "Sir! that light to the west is Roke Island!"

"I saw no light," the master roared, but even as he spoke Ged flung out his arm pointing, and all saw the light gleam clear in the west over the heaving scud and tumult of the sea.

Not for his passenger's sake, but to save his ship from the peril of the storm, the master shouted at once to the steersman to head westward toward the light. But he said to Ged, "Boy, you speak like a Seamaster, but I tell you if you lead us wrong in this weather I will throw you over to swim to Roke!"

1. In the ship, the shipmaster asks Ged to work the weather several times, and Ged says no each time, even when he thinks he is in danger of going to a lawless port. The author writes that he "must" say no to working the weather, because Ogion forbid him so, telling him he is a "landsman". What does this imply about the workings of magic? Why would Ogion forbid Ged from working spells that would be useful on his journey?
2. In the end, Ged sees light that directs them to Roke, and the shipmaster says he speaks "like a Seamaster". Did Ged act contrary to Ogion's wishes or did he act as if he were a Seamaster?